

essarily grasp what social media is all about and its impact, without operating in a silo. The new B2C companies run on these fundamentals and that, over time, helps the more conventional businesses become more agile, he explains.

“A large FMCG major today needs to look at its channel of distribution from the perspective of adding digitisation attributes. The reorientation is not only for the freshers off campus, but a reskilling across levels is the big theme.” He speaks of a large consumer company that his organisation works with where the requirement was to have a gamification of training for its blue-collar workers. “That was never the case before and it is an indication of how much things have changed.”

Deloitte’s Sagar highlights how at the entry level, jobs related to technology, AI, creativity, and sustainability are in demand. “At the mid- and senior management [levels], we are witnessing a greater focus on reskilling with a robust understanding of technology. It is pushing them to focus a lot more on cognitive, EQ (emotional quotient) and leadership skills to [get the] best out of the new generation and hone future leaders in an era of AI,” she explains.

For an organisation, a lot depends on where it is today and the industry it is in. While bifurcation of functions is very much the “done thing” today, a big development can radically change how the business is viewed. In that context, Sharma of Athena cites the example of, say, a conventional company on a

steady growth path, being acquired by a private equity fund. “Suddenly, areas like cloud service and security become very critical. The company starts to invest in that and the composition of the workforce can look very different,” he says.

TIME TO REORIENT

While the workforce is changing, where are we in terms of the change cycle? Ronesh Puri, MD of executive search firm Executive Access, says this is the beginning of a phase of much bigger changes. “The opportunities lie in the throes of multiple changes. In the next five years, we will see a transformation across businesses that will be more profound than what we saw over the last two decades.”

That will happen because India is getting a lot of global attention and it being the fastest-growing major economy makes for a heady combination, he says. “The quantum of action has increased manifold across industries and we are still in second gear. For companies, the bet is on getting it right tomorrow and to make that possible, it needs to lay the foundation today.”

Puri says the need is for transformational leaders who have a clear vision of the future. “Companies are looking for talent with adaptability, humility, maturity, and confidence. The focus is on execution skills, people skills and the ability to look at the larger picture.” Much as strategy will be a key ingredient, a sound understanding of

